

Ship It! Design Report

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Top-Level Design Description

Ship It! is an arcade game where the player tries to sort items from a conveyor belt into bins. The goal is to get as many items sorted correctly within 60 seconds.

Design Pillars

The below design pillars identify the types of fun which are key to the user experience

Application of Skill	Competition	Advancement and Completion
The game tests fast recognition and accurate placement under time pressure. Every design decision serves this (item variety, bin count and conveyor speed) all exist to keep the skill challenge sharp without becoming unfair.	The player competes against their own best score and the timer, not another player. This makes the game endlessly replayable in short bursts.	Each 60-second run is short and ends in a clear result. That loop of finishing, seeing your number, and wanting to run it again is what gives the game its replayability.

Audience & Marketing

Ship It! is designed as an all-ages casual arcade game. The sorting mechanic is simple enough for a young player to pick up immediately, while the ramping difficulty and score-chasing loop give it enough depth to hold an older player's attention. It's built as a single-player browser game, played in short, replayable sessions and not aimed at a specific age group.

Core Gameplay

The player stands behind a conveyor belt. After a small while items begin moving along it. The player moves to an item and presses space to pick it up, then carries it to the matching bin and presses space again to drop it. Sorting an item into the correct bin awards 10 points. Sorting it into the wrong bin costs 5 points. If an item reaches the end of the conveyor belt before the player picks it up, they lose 3 points.

As the round progresses, items spawn faster which forces the player to react quicker and make sorting decisions under increasing pressure. This loop continues until the 60 second timer ends at which point the final score is shown along with an option to restart.

Controls

WASD/Arrow Keys - Move

Space - Pick up items

Gameplay Balance & Pacing

The core loop is built around quick decision making rather than precision. Capping the round at 60 seconds was a deliberate choice as it's long enough for the player to notice their own mistakes and improve within a single run but short enough to keep each session feeling fun.

The item spawn rate increases over the course of the round instead of staying consistent. Early in the round items spawn slowly so the player can learn how to sort them. Halfway through the game the spawn rate has increased enough that the player must commit to sorting decisions quickly.

In the final stretch of the round the spawn rate peaks. This tests how well the player can sort under pressure. This curve means the round teaches itself in the opening seconds and gets more challenging as it gets increasingly hard until the time runs out.

Character Designs

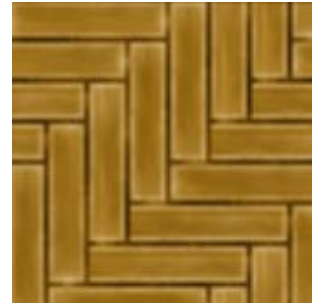
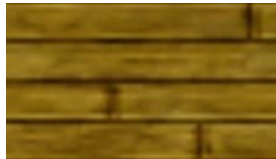
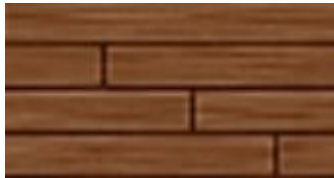
For the sprite I hand drew it each frame and tore it out. I wanted it to have a scrapbook appearance. But I learned a lesson as the sprite is too small for this to come across.



Tone & Aesthetics

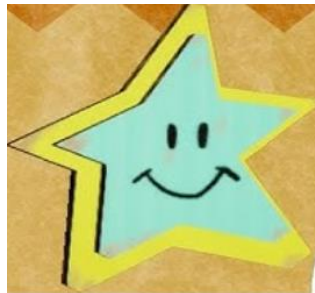
For the games background I wanted a rustic pixel art aesthetic.

Rustic



For the sprite I wanted it to evoke the appearance of being to be pasted into a scrapbook.

Mixed Media



Narrative

This is a singleplayer game without any explicit narrative. I do not intend to have dialog or characters speaking.

Business Model

Ship It! is a free-to-download game with no monetisation model. It will be made freely available to all users with no ads and no premium tiers.

The game is being developed as a portfolio project to demonstrate skills in game design and development. Its primary value is in the player experience and the learning gained through building it, rather than revenue generation.